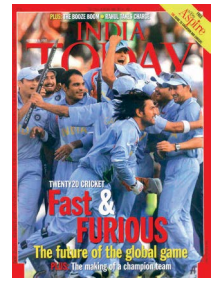
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

There's nothing like a cricketing triumph to create a feeling of joy across the country. What the Men in Blue pulled off on June 29 was much more than just a thrilling T20 cliffhanger. World Cup glory doesn't come every other day. This is only India's fourth in over four decades, across the three competition formats in which the International Cricket Council (ICC) now hands out the gold medal. So, this one floats right to the top, joining an elite list that began on a magical day at Lord's in 1983. What makes it extra special is that this comes in the hyper-charged 20-over format, where top honours had eluded India for 17 long years after it won the debut Cup.

Test cricket retains its niche allure for purists, but the Twenty20 International (T20I) has supplanted its older 50-over sibling as the holy grail of modern cricket. And not just because of its mass appeal: played at an electric pace, and unforgiving of mistakes, it demands unremitting, focused execution of skill and strategy from a Playing Eleven. That's where the helmsmanship of Rohit Sharma soared, backed by the cool head of coach Rahul Dravid. What it broke was a mental prison that seemed to paralyse our spirits when it came to the big occasion in ICC World Cups. After Kapil's Devils showed for the first time that we could do it, we had done it only twice more. Those two iterations came in 2007 and 2011, the last one being in ODIs.



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Many elements lend a historic depth to the occasion. The final in Barbados was the last time two of the modern game's giants would play a T20I. The exit of an all-time batting great like Virat Kohli and the supremely gifted Rohit from the top order marks the onset of a tricky transition. Rohit also leaves the stage as one of the only three India captains who scaled the cricketing Everest by defeating defeatism itself, and thus exorcises the ghost of the 2023 ODI WC final. His captaincy blended seemingly contrary ingredients into a perfect cocktail. Passionate, yet cool. Instinctual, but laser-sharp with method. Cheerful and full of boyish charm, but deceptively wise. That carried him through 62 T20s as captain, the eighth highest ever, without ever breaking into a sweat. Add his skippering of Mumbai Indians in 158 IPL matches, next only to M.S. Dhoni's 226, and you're talking tonnes of experience that India will now be lighter of.

It's that ticking cricketing brain which steered India through a vital strategic makeover. Nikhil Naz, Consulting Editor, Sports, India Today, explains in our cover story how that reorientation led up to a World Cup, step by step. Each of those steps was difficult because 'Ro-Ko' (Rohit-Kohli), along with Dhoni, personified the older approach of percentage cricket. A mix of aggression and risk-aversion, it had one of the main batters drop anchor till the 'death' overs and go the whole slog only then. India had been trying to coax itself out of that mindset. The goal was 'total cricket': everyone playing to maximum all the time. Instead of the total being built around gladiatorial heroes scoring big, a series of 'multi-dimensional' players were to share the load. Individual scores would matter less than the team score at all stages. The whole would be greater if it was a sum of the parts—or so went the theory. But India could never really pull it off earlier. When the big occasion arrived, they relapsed into habit. Now they have finally breathed life into the strategy—even if, paradoxically, it was a percentage Kohli knock that held up the final itself.

Of course, India could afford the luxury of all that experimentation with batting because of a certain presence in the bowling line-up. Jasprit Bumrah is the kind of gift that comes once in a blue moon, with a sublime ability to slice off scalps from an infinite variety of angles, and always with the precision of a ninja's sword. He got excellent cover fire from two southpaws: Arshdeep Singh, whose angled swing and pace made him the Cup's joint highest wicket-taker, and the tricksterism of Kuldeep Yadav. But Bumrah was the 'gun bowler' who won the war. Even when South Africa needed a mere 30 off 30, India were the favourites, because 12 out of the 30 balls belonged to him! A fast bowler as the reliable pole star—that's rare for India. But the Men in Blue found their way to the Cup around that top-class bowling unit. And at the right time for a batting great too. Dravid walks back with something he never had through his illustrious playing career: a World Cup for his cupboard.

Breaking a 13-year ICC World Cup jinx is a happy thought for India, but we cannot let such a long drought set in again. Especially because it never meant we were not good enough—rather, we tended to balk at the cusp of glory. Much more than a rampaging South Africa, it was that mind game against ourselves that we won this time. We must win it each time. An exciting future now beckons, and it will be built around generational change. In pole position to lead it is someone who has come of age in the age of T20s: Hardik Pandya. "Enfant terrible, showboat, bad boy, call him what you may, but there's another descriptor he owns: the game-changer," writes Deputy Editor Suhani Singh of the 30-year-old who will take over from the 37-year-old Rohit. With him will be a bunch that can be world-beaters, individually and collectively, in both attitude and talent. Take Rishabh Pant, 26, whose will to endure needs no introduction beyond his comeback from a life-threatening car crash; Shubman Gill, at 24 quite the poster boy for Gen Z; or Suryakumar Yadav, a late-bloomer at 33 who will force cricket lexicographers to coin a bunch of new words for batting shots before he goes. Plus, his quick-thinking acrobatic catch in the final, which turned the match in India's favour, assures us that he belongs to the future. Inside, we profile all the likely superstars of the coming Youngistan. Bumrah is now 30, so any future plan must include the idea of taking special care of his load so he can last a good few years across formats. Also expected to come in is Gautam Gambhir, who's likely to be the same stainless steel as coach as he used to be with a blade in his hand. The world better watch out.



(Aroon Purie)